

Psalms 34

Taste and See

O taste and see that the Lord is good
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *I will bless the LORD at all times: his praise shall continually be in my mouth.*
- 2 *My soul shall make her boast in the LORD: the humble shall hear thereof, and be glad.*
- 3 *O magnify the LORD with me, and let us exalt his name together.*
- 4 *I sought the LORD, and he heard me, and delivered me from all my fears.*
- 5 *They looked unto him, and were lightened: and their faces were not ashamed.*
- 6 *This poor man cried, and the LORD heard him, and saved him out of all his troubles.*
- 7 *The angel of the LORD encampeth round about them that fear him, and delivereth them.*
- 8 *O taste and see that the LORD is good: blessed is the man that trusteth in him.*
- 9 *O fear the LORD, ye his saints: for there is no want to them that fear him.*
- 10 *The young lions do lack, and suffer hunger: but they that seek the LORD shall not want any good thing.*
- 11 *Come, ye children, hearken unto me: I will teach you the fear of the LORD.*
- 12 *What man is he that desireth life, and loveth many days, that he may see good?*
- 13 *Keep thy tongue from evil, and thy lips from speaking guile.*
- 14 *Depart from evil, and do good; seek peace, and pursue it.*
- 15 *The eyes of the LORD are upon the righteous, and his ears are open unto their cry.*
- 16 *The face of the LORD is against them that do evil, to cut off the remembrance of them from the earth.*
- 17 *The righteous cry, and the LORD heareth, and delivereth them out of all their troubles.*
- 18 *The LORD is nigh unto them that are of a broken heart; and saveth such as be of a contrite spirit.*
- 19 *Many are the afflictions of the righteous: but the LORD delivereth him out of them all.*
- 20 *He keepeth all his bones: not one of them is broken.*
- 21 *Evil shall slay the wicked: and they that hate the righteous shall be desolate.*
- 22 *The LORD redeemeth the soul of his servants: and none of them that trust in him shall be desolate.*

2 · CONTEXT

Superscribed to the time David feigned madness before Achish (1 Samuel 21), Psalm 34 is a Hebrew acrostic of praise and testimony after narrow deliverance. David invites others to “taste and see” God’s goodness for themselves, teaches the fear of the Lord as the path to good days, and promises nearness to the brokenhearted. The New Testament draws on it repeatedly (1 Peter 3:10–12; John 19:36 on verse 20), showing its lasting place in Christian devotion.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

A vow to bless the Lord “at all times” and to boast in Him rather than in circumstances; an invitation to magnify the Lord together with others who share the testimony.

Verse 4-7

He sought the Lord and was delivered from his fears; those who “look unto him” are lightened, unashamed. The poor man cried and was saved out of all his troubles, and the angel of the Lord encamps round about those who fear Him.

Verse 8-10

The famous invitation: “O taste and see that the Lord is good.” Blessed is the one who trusts Him; those who fear the Lord shall lack nothing good, even while young lions may go hungry.

Verse 11-14

A teaching section addressed to “children”—come, hear, and be taught the fear of the Lord: keep the tongue from evil, depart from evil and do good, seek peace and pursue it.

Verse 15-18

The eyes of the Lord are on the righteous, His ears open to their cry, but His face is against evildoers. He hears the righteous and delivers them out of all their troubles; He is near to the brokenhearted and saves the contrite in spirit.

Verse 19-22

Many are the afflictions of the righteous, but the Lord delivers out of them all and keeps all his bones (fulfilled at the cross, John 19:36). Evil slays the wicked in the end, but the Lord redeems the soul of His servants; none who trust in Him shall be desolate.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Goodness tasted firsthand is more persuasive than goodness merely described—David invites experiential trust, not blind assent. The fear of the Lord produces both practical wisdom (guarded speech, pursued peace) and real nearness to the brokenhearted, even though affliction is not promised away.

Application for life today.

Rather than only reading about God’s goodness, actively “taste” it this week—notice specific answered prayers, provisions, or comforts and name them as His goodness. If you are brokenhearted or crushed in spirit right now, verse 18 promises God is near, not distant, in exactly that condition. Practice verses 13–14 concretely: guard one habit of speech and pursue peace in one strained relationship.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

- 1.** What is one specific way you have “tasted” God’s goodness recently that you could name out loud to someone else?
- 2.** Where do you need to believe verse 18—that God is near to the brokenhearted—rather than feeling abandoned in a hard season?
- 3.** What would it look like to “seek peace, and pursue it” (v. 14) in a relationship you have been avoiding?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).